



The Auto Repair Playbook

Twenty AI workflows for independent auto repair shops — built for owners, service advisors, and technicians.

What's inside

Repair-order write-ups, DVI narratives, and tech-to-customer translations that customers approve

Estimate follow-up, declined-service reactivation, and slow-bay fill campaigns

Review generation, maintenance reminders, referral asks, and seasonal campaigns

Authorization scripts, price-shopper calls, after-hours voicemail triage, and loaner/shuttle messaging

A monthly numbers review built on your shop's own car count, ARO, and close rate

12 months of free updates — every improvement ships to your inbox

WORKFLOW 01 OF 20

The RO Write-Up — Estimates Customers Actually Approve

A prompt that turns your line items into a repair order a non-mechanical customer will read and approve: each job gets a plain-English title, one sentence on what the repair does, one sentence on why it matters for this vehicle, and an honest urgency note — so the estimate sells itself instead of stalling at the front counter.

Estimated time-to-run: 10 minutes per estimate

01

ChatGPT or Claude, plus your shop management system's estimate builder (Tekmetric, Shop-Ware, or similar)

HOW TO INPUT

Step 1: **Copy the estimate's line items.** Open the open repair order and note each job name, the parts and labor, and the total — plus what the technician actually found.

Step 2: **Replace the placeholders** with the customer's first name, the year/make/model and mileage, and the real findings. Use first names only in the AI.

Step 3: **Paste the plain-language descriptions into the estimate** before sending it to the customer, keeping your original line-item totals untouched.

PROMPT

You are a service advisor writing a repair estimate a non-mechanical customer will read. For each line item below, write: (1) a plain-English job title – no part numbers, no shop jargon; (2) one sentence on what the repair does; (3) one sentence on why it matters for THIS vehicle, using the technician's actual findings; (4) an honest urgency note – now, soon, or monitor. Rules: describe only the findings given; never invent symptoms, specs, failure consequences, or prices; keep each line item under 60 words. Customer first name: [FIRST NAME]. Vehicle: [YEAR MAKE MODEL, MILEAGE]. Tech findings: [LINE ITEM – WHAT WAS FOUND – one per line].

EXPECTED OUTPUT

Customer-ready line-item descriptions, ready to paste into the estimate without touching the totals.

Step time estimate: 10 minutes per estimate

WORKFLOW 02 OF 20

The DVI Narrative — Tech Notes and Photos Into Customer-Ready Inspections

A prompt that converts technician shorthand and DVI photos into inspection write-ups customers understand: green/yellow/red findings translated into plain English, each with an honest urgency and the "what happens if I wait" note the advisor used to write from scratch.

Estimated time-to-run: 10 minutes per inspection

02

ChatGPT or Claude, plus your shop's digital vehicle inspection tool (the DVI in Tekmetric, Shop-Ware, or similar)

HOW TO INPUT

Step 1: **Gather the inspection record.** Open the completed DVI: read the tech's notes and condition ratings (good/attention/immediate) and look at the photos.

Step 2: **Describe the photos in words for the AI** — do not upload customer vehicle photos; paste the tech's notes and your plain-language photo descriptions, with first names only.

Step 3: **Paste the AI's write-ups into the DVI notes** beside the photos, and have the advisor scan them once before sending the inspection link.

PROMPT

You are a service advisor writing customer-facing notes for a digital vehicle inspection. For each finding below, write: (1) a plain-English headline – what the part is and what is wrong with it; (2) 2 sentences explaining it to a non-mechanical customer – what the part does and why this condition matters; (3) an urgency of NOW, SOON, or MONITOR, matching the technician's rating, with one honest sentence on what waiting looks like. Rules: never soften a real safety issue, never inflate a cosmetic one; use only the findings given; keep each write-up under 75 words. Findings: [TECH RATING – PART – TECH NOTE – PHOTO DESCRIBED IN WORDS – one per finding]. Vehicle: [YEAR MAKE MODEL].

EXPECTED OUTPUT

A customer-ready DVI narrative per finding, ready to sit beside the photos in the inspection.

Step time estimate: 10 minutes per inspection

WORKFLOW 03 OF 20

The Declined Estimate Follow-Up — Day 2, Day 7, Day 14

A prompt that builds a three-touch follow-up sequence for estimates the customer declined or went quiet on: a day-2 thank-you with the open door, a day-7 helpful nudge, and a day-14 honest close — so declined work stops disappearing into silence.

Estimated time-to-run: 10 minutes per estimate

03

ChatGPT or Claude, plus your shop management system's estimate history and two-way texting

HOW TO INPUT

Step 1: **Pull this week's declined or unanswered estimates.** Note the customer first name, the vehicle, the work quoted, the total, and what the advisor heard (too much money, second opinion, "I'll think about it").

Step 2: **Replace the placeholders** — first names only, real totals, the real reason if you know it.

Step 3: **Send the sequence on schedule** — day 2 text, day 7 email or text, day 14 final check — and log each send on the repair order.

PROMPT

You are a service advisor following up on a declined or unanswered estimate. Write three messages: (1) DAY 2 — a text under 40 words, thanks them for coming in, names the one most important item on the estimate, says the quote is good as written, ends with a yes/no question; (2) DAY 7 — under 80 words, adds one useful detail (a symptom to watch for, the honest urgency of the top item), no discount invented; (3) DAY 14 — under 60 words, polite and direct: asks if they want to book, get a revised quote, or have us close the ticket. No exclamation points, no fake urgency, no price shaving. Customer first name: [FIRST NAME]. Vehicle: [YEAR MAKE MODEL]. Work quoted: [TOP ITEM + TOTAL]. Reason given: [REASON OR "NO REASON"].

EXPECTED OUTPUT

A three-touch follow-up sequence matched to the estimate, ready to send on schedule.

Step time estimate: 10 minutes per estimate

WORKFLOW 04 OF 20

The Review Engine — Reviews Right After Pickup

A prompt that writes your review-request copy — the pickup-time ask plus two follow-ups — and drafts replies to the reviews that land, so every completed repair order feeds your Google and shop reputation while the experience is still fresh.

Estimated time-to-run: 20 minutes to set up, 5 minutes per review reply

04

ChatGPT or Claude, plus your shop management system's automated review requests or texting (triggered at vehicle pickup or repair-order close)

HOW TO INPUT

Step 1: **Confirm your review ask.** Check how you request reviews today — automated text at pickup, printed card, or manual — and note your review link and whether you ask by text, email, or both.

Step 2: **Replace the placeholders** — shop name, review link, the services you want named.

Step 3: **Put the copy into your system** (automation text or printed card at the counter), and use the reply drafts for each new review.

PROMPT

You are the owner of an independent repair shop setting up review collection. Write: (1) the PICKUP ASK – under 160 characters if text, thanks the customer by first name, names the work done, one link, no begging; (2) a first follow-up for 3 days later – shorter, assumes they meant to get to it; (3) a second follow-up for 5 days later – final, gracious, no guilt; (4) three reply templates – one for 5-star, one for 4-star, one for a negative review (acknowledge, take it offline, give a name and number – never argue the facts in public). Shop: [SHOP NAME]. Work done: [SERVICE]. Review link: [URL].

EXPECTED OUTPUT

A pickup ask plus two follow-ups ready to use, and reply templates for 5-star, 4-star, and negative reviews.

Step time estimate: 20 minutes to set up, 5 minutes per review reply

WORKFLOW 05 OF 20

The Maintenance Reminder — Oil, Brakes, and Tires on Mileage and Time

A prompt that turns your repair-order history into a monthly reminder list: who is due for an oil change, brake check, or tire rotation by mileage or by calendar — and writes the actual reminder texts, so the work comes back to your bays instead of going to the quick-lube down the road.

Estimated time-to-run: 20 minutes per month

05

ChatGPT or Claude, plus your shop management system's customer and vehicle history reports (Tekmetric, Shop-Ware, or similar)

HOW TO INPUT

Step 1: **Pull the due list.** In your system, sort customers by last visit date and last recorded mileage; flag vehicles due for oil (by miles or months), brakes (by last brake job date and mileage), and tires (rotation interval or age).

Step 2: **Copy the due rows and replace the placeholders** — first names, vehicle, what is due and why (miles since last service or months elapsed). No full addresses in the AI.

Step 3: **Send the reminders in batches** — text first, email for the ones who don't respond — and log bookings on the schedule.

PROMPT

You are a service advisor sending maintenance reminders that feel personal, not automated. For each customer below, write a text under 40 words: use their first name, name the vehicle, state exactly what is due and the real reason (miles since last service or months elapsed — whichever you were given), give one booking option ("we have Tuesday open"), end with a yes/no question. Rules: only remind for services the history supports; never invent mileage or dates; keep it warm, not nagging. Due list: [FIRST NAME — VEHICLE — SERVICE DUE — MILES/MONTHS SINCE LAST — one per line]. Booking option: [DAY/TIME OFFER].

EXPECTED OUTPUT

A ready-to-send reminder text per due customer, matched to real service history.

Step time estimate: 20 minutes per month

WORKFLOW 06 OF 20

The Parts Quote Check — OEM vs Aftermarket Price Comparison

A prompt that turns your parts list into a clean sourcing worksheet: for each part, where to quote it (dealer, your regular suppliers, online OEM sellers), what to compare besides price, and the advisor-ready line for explaining the OEM/aftermarket choice to the customer.

Estimated time-to-run: 15 minutes per repair order

06

ChatGPT or Claude, plus your supplier price lookups and the repair order's parts list

HOW TO INPUT

Step 1: **List the parts.** From the repair order, write each part needed, the vehicle, and whether quality or warranty terms restrict the choice (e.g., a part you only install as OEM).

Step 2: **Paste the list and replace the placeholders** — real part names and the suppliers you actually use.

Step 3: **Work the comparison** — quote the real suppliers, record the winning source, and use the AI's customer line when presenting the choice.

PROMPT

You are a shop owner sourcing parts smartly. For each part below, build a sourcing row: (1) where to quote – dealer parts counter, your regular jobber/suppliers, and one reputable online OEM source (only sources you name); (2) what to compare besides price – warranty terms, availability/delivery time, and core charge if any; (3) a one-sentence advisor line for the customer explaining the OEM vs aftermarket choice for THIS part, honest about the tradeoff. Rules: never invent part prices, part numbers, or supplier names; work only from what is given. Parts: [PART NAME – VEHICLE – ANY CONSTRAINT, e.g. "OEM ONLY"]. Suppliers you use: [SUPPLIER NAMES].

EXPECTED OUTPUT

A parts sourcing worksheet with comparison points and a customer-ready line per part.

Step time estimate: 15 minutes per repair order

WORKFLOW 07 OF 20

The Declined-Service Wake-Up — Win Back the Work They Said No To

A prompt that mines your estimate history for declined work worth a second look: the AI scores each one by age, dollar value, and safety relevance, then writes the reactivation message — so last quarter's "no" becomes this month's scheduled work.

Estimated time-to-run: 25 minutes per month

07

ChatGPT or Claude, plus your shop management system's declined-estimate or lost-sales report (Tekmetric, Shop-Ware, or similar)

HOW TO INPUT

Step 1: **Pull declined estimates from the last 90 days.** Note customer first name, vehicle, work quoted, total, date declined, and the reason if recorded.

Step 2: **Copy the rows and replace the placeholders** — first names only, real totals and dates.

Step 3: **Work the list top-down** — call safety items, text the rest, and log outcomes on the repair orders.

PROMPT

You are a service advisor reactivating declined estimates. For each estimate below: (1) score it CALL, TEXT, or SKIP — CALL means a safety item or a ticket over [THRESHOLD] declined within 45 days; TEXT means routine maintenance or smaller repairs; SKIP means declined 90+ days ago with no contact since; (2) for CALL and TEXT, write a message under 60 words — name the customer by first name, name the vehicle and the specific work, give one honest reason to do it now (only if true — seasonal angle, a symptom to watch, nothing invented), end with a booking question. No discounts invented, no scare tactics. Estimates: [FIRST NAME — VEHICLE — WORK QUOTED — TOTAL — DATE DECLINED — REASON IF KNOWN — one per line].

EXPECTED OUTPUT

A scored reactivation list with a ready-to-send message per live estimate.

Step time estimate: 25 minutes per month

WORKFLOW 08 OF 20

The Authorization Script — Service-Advisor Phone Scripts That Get a Yes

A prompt that writes the actual words for authorization calls: the tech found something extra mid-job, the estimate needs approval, the customer is price-nervous — the AI drafts a calm, clear script per situation, so every advisor sounds like your best advisor.

Estimated time-to-run: 5 minutes per call prep

08

ChatGPT or Claude, plus the repair order and the technician's findings

HOW TO INPUT

Step 1: **Note the situation.** Write down what needs authorization — the additional finding, the revised total, and anything you know about the customer (first-timer, price-sensitive, already approved the base work).

Step 2: **Replace the placeholders** — first name only, the real finding and real numbers.

Step 3: **Call with the script in front of you**, and log the authorization (approved/declined, by whom, time) on the repair order.

PROMPT

You are a veteran service advisor coaching a newer one through an authorization call. Write a phone script under 150 words: (1) the opening — first name, where the car is in the process, the one-line finding in plain English; (2) the explanation — what we recommend, the honest urgency, the total with the addition; (3) the ask — a direct but easy yes/no; (4) two objection replies — one for "how much is that exactly" and one for "can it wait" — answered honestly from the findings, never pressured. Tone: calm, peer-to-peer, no jargon. Situation: [WHAT NEEDS AUTHORIZATION]. Finding: [TECH'S FINDING IN PLAIN WORDS]. Current total / new total: [AMOUNTS]. Customer note: [FIRST-TIMER / PRICE-SENSITIVE / RETURNING — if known].

EXPECTED OUTPUT

A ready-to-read authorization script with two honest objection replies.

Step time estimate: 5 minutes per call prep

WORKFLOW 09 OF 20

The Warranty File — Documentation That Protects Every Repair

A prompt that builds your warranty documentation standard: for each completed repair, the AI drafts the warranty note — what was done, which parts and warranty terms apply, what the customer must do to keep coverage — so every ticket leaves the shop with its paper trail already written.

Estimated time-to-run: 10 minutes per repair order

09

ChatGPT or Claude, plus the completed repair order and your shop's warranty terms

HOW TO INPUT

Step 1: **Gather the completed work.** Open the closed repair order: parts installed (with part brand/type as invoiced), labor performed, and the warranty terms you actually offer (e.g., your standard parts-and-labor period).

Step 2: **Replace the placeholders** — real terms from your written warranty policy, real parts, first names only.

Step 3: **Attach the warranty note to the repair order** and hand or email the customer copy at pickup.

PROMPT

You are a shop owner documenting warranty coverage on a completed repair. Write a warranty note: (1) what was done — 2 sentences, plain English, naming the parts installed as invoiced; (2) the coverage — state ONLY the warranty terms given below, in plain language (what is covered, for how long, parts and labor); (3) what the customer must do to keep coverage — e.g., return to this shop for the warranty work, keep the invoice (only real requirements you list); (4) one line on what is NOT covered, stated plainly. Rules: never extend, invent, or assume warranty terms; if a part's coverage is unknown, write "per manufacturer's terms — ask us" rather than guessing. Repair: [WORK DONE + PARTS INSTALLED]. Your warranty terms: [YOUR ACTUAL TERMS]. Coverage requirements: [REQUIREMENTS].

EXPECTED OUTPUT

A plain-language warranty note ready to attach to the repair order and hand to the customer.

Step time estimate: 10 minutes per repair order

WORKFLOW 10 OF 20

The Fleet Proposal — One Account, Many Vehicles

A prompt that turns a local business's vehicle list into a fleet-service proposal: preventive-maintenance schedule per vehicle, a simple rate structure, and the pitch that wins the account — so one conversation becomes a dozen vehicles on your lift every month.

Estimated time-to-run: 45 minutes per proposal

10

ChatGPT or Claude, plus the prospect's vehicle list and your shop's labor rate and service menu

HOW TO INPUT

Step 1: **List the fleet.** Get the business's vehicles — year/make/model, mileage, and use (delivery, service calls, sales) — and note your shop's labor rate and the services you want to lead with.

Step 2: **Replace the placeholders** — real vehicle list, real rates, only services you genuinely perform.

Step 3: **Send the proposal and follow up in person** — fleet deals close on relationships, not PDFs.

PROMPT

You are a shop owner pitching a fleet maintenance account. Build a proposal: (1) the offer — one paragraph on what fleet service means at your shop (scheduled preventive maintenance, priority scheduling terms you can actually honor, one monthly statement); (2) a per-vehicle maintenance schedule — oil, tires, brakes, inspections — based on the mileage and use given, stated as intervals not promises about outcomes; (3) the rate structure — your real labor rate and how fleet pricing works (flat discount, tiered, or menu pricing — only what you decide); (4) a one-page pitch email under 150 words to the fleet manager. Rules: never promise uptime, breakdown prevention, or savings figures you cannot prove; every commitment must be one you will honor. Fleet: [VEHICLE — MILEAGE — USE — one per line]. Your labor rate: [RATE]. Fleet pricing approach: [APPROACH]. Shop: [SHOP NAME].

EXPECTED OUTPUT

A fleet proposal with per-vehicle schedules, a rate structure, and a pitch email.

Step time estimate: 45 minutes per proposal

WORKFLOW 11 OF 20

The Slow-Bay Sprint — Fill Open Bays This Week

A prompt that turns a light schedule into a filled one: the AI ranks who to contact from your declined estimates, due-maintenance list, and past customers — and writes the exact text for each — so a slow week becomes booked work instead of idle lifts.

Estimated time-to-run: 15 minutes per slow week

11

ChatGPT or Claude, plus your shop management system's schedule, declined estimates, and customer history

HOW TO INPUT

Step 1: **Find the opening and the candidates.** Note the open bay days and times, then pull candidates: recent declined estimates, customers due for maintenance, and past customers not seen in a while — first names and the fit.

Step 2: **Replace the placeholders** — first names only, real opening times, real reasons each candidate fits.

Step 3: **Text top-down and book the first yes** straight into the schedule.

PROMPT

You are a service advisor with open bay time to fill this week. Rank the candidates below by likelihood to book (declined estimate with a safety item > customer due for maintenance > past customer not seen in a while), and write a text for each under 40 words: use their first name, name the specific opening (day + time), name the work they need, give one honest reason it suits them, end with a yes/no question. No exclamation points, no fake scarcity, no invented discounts. Openings: [DAY, TIME WINDOW — one per line]. Candidates: [FIRST NAME — WORK NEEDED — WHY THEY FIT — one per line].

EXPECTED OUTPUT

A ranked call list with a ready-to-send text per candidate.

Step time estimate: 15 minutes per slow week

WORKFLOW 12 OF 20

The Timing Belt Talk — Customer Education That Prevents Catastrophe

A prompt that writes the education pieces your advisors wish they had time to write: why the timing belt cannot wait, what a "monitor" brake finding actually means, why the coolant flush matters — plain-English explainers the customer reads before they decide, so the recommendation lands on understanding instead of pressure.

Estimated time-to-run: 20 minutes per explainer (reusable forever)

12**ChatGPT or Claude, plus the technician's findings for the vehicle in question**

HOW TO INPUT

Step 1: **Pick the topic the shop explains most.** Timing belt intervals, brake wear stages, coolant and transmission service, tire age — whatever your advisors repeat daily.

Step 2: **Replace the placeholders** — the real finding or interval for the vehicle at hand, first names only.

Step 3: **Save the good ones** — build a small library of explainers the whole counter team can send.

PROMPT

You are a master technician explaining a repair to a smart non-mechanical friend. Write a customer explainer under 150 words: (1) what the part or service is, in one plain sentence; (2) what happens as it wears – described honestly, using only the facts given; (3) what "wait" really means for this vehicle – the honest consequence range, no horror stories invented; (4) the one question the customer should ask us before deciding. Rules: never invent failure timelines, costs of catastrophic damage, or manufacturer intervals – use only what is provided; if you do not know the consequence for certain, say what is known and what to ask the technician. Topic: [SERVICE OR PART]. Vehicle: [YEAR MAKE MODEL, MILEAGE]. Known facts: [INTERVAL OR FINDING AS GIVEN].

EXPECTED OUTPUT

A plain-English explainer the advisor can text or email before the customer decides.

Step time estimate: 20 minutes per explainer (reusable forever)

WORKFLOW 13 OF 20

The Tech-to-Customer Translation — Notes Into Summaries

A prompt that converts a technician's bay shorthand into the summary the advisor sends at pickup: what was done today, what was found, what to watch — so the tech keeps writing like a tech, and the customer still gets a message that reads like it was written for them.

Estimated time-to-run: 5 minutes per repair order

13 ChatGPT or Claude, plus the repair order's technician notes

HOW TO INPUT

Step 1: **Copy the tech's notes.** Open the completed repair order and copy the technician's write-up verbatim — shorthand, abbreviations, and all.

Step 2: **Paste the notes and replace the placeholders** — first name only, vehicle, work performed.

Step 3: **Send the summary** by text or email at pickup, and file it on the repair order.

PROMPT

You are a service advisor writing the pickup summary for a customer. Turn the technician's notes below into a customer message under 120 words: (1) what we did today – 2-3 sentences in plain English; (2) what we found – anything the tech flagged, described without jargon and without alarm; (3) what to watch or do next – only real next steps, with honest urgency (now, soon, whenever). Rules: never add findings the tech did not write; never translate a "monitor" into an emergency; keep the tech's meaning intact. Tech notes: [PASTE VERBATIM]. Customer first name: [FIRST NAME]. Vehicle: [YEAR MAKE MODEL]. Work performed: [JOBS COMPLETED].

EXPECTED OUTPUT

A warm, plain-English pickup summary ready to send, faithful to the tech's notes.

Step time estimate: 5 minutes per repair order

WORKFLOW 14 OF 20

The After-Hours Triage — Voicemail to Morning Game Plan

A prompt that turns Monday morning's voicemail pile into a prioritized callback list: the AI sorts each message by urgency, drafts the callback note, and flags what needs a bay held — so the first hour of the week runs on a plan instead of a scramble.

Estimated time-to-run: 15 minutes each Monday morning

14 ChatGPT or Claude, plus your shop's voicemail or after-hours message log

HOW TO INPUT

Step 1: **Transcribe the messages.** Listen to each after-hours voicemail and jot the caller's first name, vehicle if given, the problem in their words, and any urgency clues (stranded, leaking, noise, "whenever you can").

Step 2: **Paste the summaries and replace the placeholders** — first names and callback numbers stay in your system, not in the AI beyond what you need.

Step 3: **Work the list top-down** — call the urgent first, hold bays where the AI flags them.

PROMPT

You are a service manager triaging after-hours voicemails on Monday morning. For each message below: (1) score it URGENT (vehicle undriveable, safety issue, customer stranded), TODAY (needs diagnosis today, customer waiting on the car), or ROUTINE (scheduling, quotes, general questions); (2) write a one-line callback note – who, what, and the first question to ask; (3) flag any message where we should hold a bay or warn the customer about a possible tow-in. Base urgency only on what the caller said – do not diagnose from a voicemail. Messages: [FIRST NAME – VEHICLE IF GIVEN – PROBLEM IN THEIR WORDS – one per line].

EXPECTED OUTPUT

A prioritized Monday callback list with notes and bay-hold flags.

Step time estimate: 15 minutes each Monday morning

WORKFLOW 15 OF 20

The Loaner and Shuttle Line — Keep Them Moving While We Fix It

A prompt that writes the loaner and shuttle messaging your counter runs on: the availability text, the pickup coordination, the return reminder — so customers stay mobile and your loaner fleet stops being a scheduling headache.

Estimated time-to-run: 10 minutes to set up the templates

15**ChatGPT or Claude, plus your shop's loaner/shuttle schedule or sign-out sheet**

HOW TO INPUT

Step 1: **Note your real policy.** Write down how loaners and shuttles actually work at your shop — who qualifies, how far the shuttle runs, fuel/return expectations.

Step 2: **Replace the placeholders** — your actual policy details, shop name, first names only.

Step 3: **Save the templates** where the advisors can grab them — counter binder or shared note.

PROMPT

You are a service advisor writing loaner and shuttle messages. Write four templates: (1) the AVAILABILITY text – under 40 words, tells the customer a loaner or shuttle is available for their repair day, states the one key condition from the policy; (2) the BOOKING confirmation – confirms the date, pickup time, and where to meet; (3) the DAY-OF reminder – sent the morning of, under 30 words; (4) the RETURN reminder – states return time, fuel expectation, and where to leave the keys. Rules: every detail must come from the policy given – never invent mileage limits, fees, or service areas. Policy: [YOUR LOANER/SHUTTLE POLICY AS IT REALLY IS]. Shop: [SHOP NAME]. Customer first name: [FIRST NAME].

EXPECTED OUTPUT

Four copy-paste loaner/shuttle templates matched to your real policy.

Step time estimate: 10 minutes to set up the templates

WORKFLOW 16 OF 20

The Check-Engine-Light Intake — Questions That Save Diagnostic Time

A prompt that builds the intake script for check-engine-light calls and drop-offs: the exact questions the advisor asks before the car ever hits the lift, and the plain-English explanation of what the diagnostic fee covers — so the tech starts with clues instead of a blank ticket.

Estimated time-to-run: 5 minutes per intake

16 ChatGPT or Claude, plus the customer's description of the symptom

HOW TO INPUT

Step 1: **Write down what the customer said.** The light's behavior (steady or flashing), any symptoms (noise, smell, performance change), and when it started — in their words.

Step 2: **Replace the placeholders** — first name only, vehicle, their description verbatim.

Step 3: **Ask the questions on the call or at drop-off**, and attach the answers to the repair order for the technician.

PROMPT

You are a service advisor taking in a check-engine-light concern. Write: (1) five intake questions for the customer — plain English, answerable by a non-mechanical person (when the light came on, steady or flashing, any change in how it drives, any recent work or fuel fill-up, when they need the car back); (2) a two-sentence explanation of what the diagnostic fee covers and why we charge it before quoting repairs — honest, no jargon; (3) a one-line note template for the repair order capturing the answers for the technician. Rules: never guess the cause from the description; if the customer reports a flashing light or severe symptom, include the "bring it in now / consider a tow" guidance as a safety note, not a diagnosis. Customer description: [THEIR WORDS]. Vehicle: [YEAR MAKE MODEL].

EXPECTED OUTPUT

Five intake questions, a diagnostic-fee explanation, and a repair-order note template.

Step time estimate: 5 minutes per intake

WORKFLOW 17 OF 20

The Seasonal Campaign — AC Checks and Winterization

A prompt that turns your customer list into a seasonal service campaign: who to contact for AC performance checks before summer and winterization before the cold — with the emails and texts written, segmented by vehicle age and last service date.

Estimated time-to-run: 45 minutes per campaign

17

ChatGPT or Claude, plus your shop management system's customer history report and your texting or email tool

HOW TO INPUT

Step 1: **Build the segments.** From your customer history, group by: vehicles 5+ years old not seen in 6+ months (AC check candidates), and all daily drivers not winterized last fall (winterization candidates). Counts and vehicle types only — no full records in the AI.

Step 2: **Replace the placeholders** — your real offer (e.g., an AC performance check at your real price, or a winterization package you actually sell).

Step 3: **Send in segment order** and book replies straight into the schedule.

PROMPT

You are a marketer for an independent repair shop planning a seasonal campaign. Given the segments below, write: (1) one message per segment — a text under 40 words or an email under 120 words (subject line included for email) — naming the season, the service, and the real offer, ending with a booking question; (2) a send order — which segment first and why; (3) one follow-up text for non-responders a week later. Rules: every offer must be real and bookable at the price stated; no fake deadlines ("offer ends Friday" unless it truly does); never claim a service prevents breakdowns. Segments: [SEGMENT NAME — WHO THEY ARE — COUNT]. Season and offer: [SEASON, SERVICE, PRICE].

EXPECTED OUTPUT

One message per segment with a send order and a follow-up text — ready to send.

Step time estimate: 45 minutes per campaign

WORKFLOW 18 OF 20

The Referral Ask — Your Best Customers Bring the Next Ones

A prompt that writes the referral ask for the moment it works best — right after a great pickup — plus the follow-up and the thank-you, so your happiest customers do your marketing for you.

Estimated time-to-run: 10 minutes to set up, 2 minutes per ask

18 ChatGPT or Claude, plus your pickup routine and any referral reward you actually offer

HOW TO INPUT

Step 1: **Decide the reward (if any).** A real thank-you you will honor — a discount on their next visit, a gift card — or no reward at all, just the ask. Write down exactly what it is.

Step 2: **Replace the placeholders** — shop name, the reward as it really is (or "no reward"), first names only.

Step 3: **Make it part of pickup** — the advisor asks when the customer is smiling, and sends the follow-up text that evening.

PROMPT

You are a shop owner who gets most new business by word of mouth. Write: (1) the PICKUP ASK — a 2-sentence spoken script for the advisor, warm and specific ("if you know anyone with a [vehicle type] who needs a shop they can trust..."), naming the reward only if one exists; (2) the EVENING FOLLOW-UP text — under 40 words, thanks them again, includes the ask and a simple way to refer (forward this text, mention our name); (3) the THANK-YOU text for when a referral books — under 30 words, names the reward if there is one. Rules: never invent a reward; if there is none, the ask stands on the relationship alone. Shop: [SHOP NAME]. Reward: [REWARD OR "NONE"]. Happy-customer example: [FIRST NAME — WORK DONE].

EXPECTED OUTPUT

A pickup script, a follow-up text, and a referral thank-you — ready to use at the counter.

Step time estimate: 10 minutes to set up, 2 minutes per ask

WORKFLOW 19 OF 20

The Price Shopper — Handling "How Much for Brakes?" Calls

A prompt that turns the dreaded price-shopping call into a booked appointment: the questions that uncover what they actually need, the honest answer on why a phone quote is a range, and the close that gets the car in for a real inspection.

Estimated time-to-run: 5 minutes per call

19 ChatGPT or Claude, plus your shop's real price ranges for common jobs

HOW TO INPUT

Step 1: **Note what they asked.** The job they named, the vehicle, and anything they volunteered (noise, warning light, another shop's quote).

Step 2: **Replace the placeholders** — your real price range for that job, first names only.

Step 3: **Use the script on the call** and book the inspection — the range gets them in, the DVI closes the sale.

PROMPT

You are a veteran service advisor handling a price-shopping call. Write a call script under 150 words: (1) the honest opener – thank them for calling, give the real price range for the job named, and say plainly why it is a range until we see the vehicle (pad/rotor condition, hardware, related findings); (2) two qualifying questions that uncover the real need (what symptom, when it started); (3) the inspection close – offer the inspection at its real price (or free if that is your policy), name the next available slot, end with a yes/no booking question. Rules: quote only the real range given; never trash-talk the competitor or their quote; never promise the bottom of the range. Job asked about: [JOB]. Vehicle: [YEAR MAKE MODEL]. Your real price range: [RANGE]. Inspection offer: [PRICE OR "FREE"].

EXPECTED OUTPUT

A price-shopper call script that gives an honest range and books the inspection.

Step time estimate: 5 minutes per call

WORKFLOW 20 OF 20

The Monthly Numbers Review — Car Count, ARO, Close Rate

A prompt that turns your shop management system's monthly reports into a one-page action plan: car count, average repair order, and estimate close rate become three moves for next month — so the numbers stop being trivia and start being decisions.

Estimated time-to-run: 30 minutes per month

20

ChatGPT or Claude, plus your shop management system's monthly reports — car count, sales, average repair order, estimate/close reports (Tekmetric, Shop-Ware, or similar)

HOW TO INPUT

Step 1: **Pull the month's numbers.** From your system: total car count (repair orders), total sales, average repair order, estimates written vs approved (close rate), and last month's figures for comparison.

Step 2: **Paste the numbers and replace the placeholders** — aggregate figures only, no customer-level data in the AI.

Step 3: **Run the plan** — assign each action to a person and a date, and review it at month's end.

PROMPT

You are a no-nonsense business coach reviewing an independent shop's month. Given the numbers below, write a one-page plan: (1) the headline — one sentence on how the month went versus last month (car count up or down, ARO up or down, close rate up or down); (2) three actions for next month, each with an owner (owner, advisor, tech) and a done-by date — specific and small enough to finish, drawn from the numbers (e.g., close-rate slipped: tighten the day-2 estimate follow-up); (3) one thing to stop doing. Base everything only on the numbers given — do not invent benchmarks, industry averages, or targets. Numbers: [CAR COUNT, TOTAL SALES, AVERAGE REPAIR ORDER, ESTIMATES WRITTEN, ESTIMATES APPROVED, CLOSE RATE]. Last month: [SAME FIGURES FOR COMPARISON]. Goals you set: [GOALS IF ANY].

EXPECTED OUTPUT

A one-page monthly action plan: headline, three owned actions, one thing to stop.

Step time estimate: 30 minutes per month

Your AI stack

Every playbook ends with the stack — the minimal set of subscriptions this work actually requires, and the ones to skip. AI subscription confusion is a real adoption barrier: too many tools, overlapping jobs, money leaking every month to dashboards nobody opens. Here is the honest minimum for an independent auto repair shop.

What you need

One AI assistant subscription. This is the machine you author with: the one that drafts your estimate write-ups, turns tech notes into customer-ready inspection narratives, and does the “figuring out” before anything gets pasted into the shop system. ChatGPT or Claude — pick the one you actually open every day. One, not both. The test is usage: if you open it daily, it earns its place; if you open it monthly, it doesn’t.

Your shop management system — the one you already pay for. Tekmetric, Shop-Ware, or similar. The workflows in this book are written for its estimate builder, its DVI, its monthly car-count, ARO, and close-rate reports, and the texting and email already inside it — not around them. This is not a new subscription; it is a job for a tool you own.

What to skip

A second, overlapping AI subscription. Two assistants doing the same authoring job is paying twice for one job. Pick one and commit.

A paid “AI marketing add-on” until it earns its keep. If the assistant plus the texting, review requests, and reminders already inside your shop system covers estimate follow-up and slow-bay fill, the add-on is redundant until your own numbers prove otherwise.

Anything sold as “AI” that you can’t assign a weekly job. The standing test for every subscription: name the job it does each week. If you can’t name it, cancel it. Check quarterly — stacks grow back like weeds.

The minimal stack

NEED: - ONE AI assistant subscription (ChatGPT or Claude) — pick the one you open daily; this is what you author with - Your existing shop management system (Tekmetric, Shop-Ware, or similar) — estimate builder, DVI, monthly reports, and texting you already pay for

SKIP: - A second overlapping AI subscription — paying twice for one authoring job - Paid AI marketing add-ons until your numbers prove the need - Anything you can’t assign a weekly job — name its job each week, or cancel it

Review quarterly. Stacks grow back like weeds.

Thank you

Thank you for reading — and for doing the unglamorous part. Writing the estimate a customer can actually understand, calling back on the declined job, asking for the review: none of it is exciting. All of it is the difference between a shop that earns trust and a shop that leaks it.

If this book has a single sentence, it is the one SkillForge AI was built on: we don't lie, we don't steal, we offer value. Describe only real findings. Send follow-ups worth receiving. Quote honest ranges — and when you find a claim you can't prove, either prove it or remove it the same day. The AI will make you fast. The ethic is what makes you worth buying from.

Go run your next workflow like it matters. Because it does.

— *SkillForge AI*

Questions about this playbook: skillforge-ai-im76wv@polsia.app